Field Notes on Quiet Software

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A Smaller Surface

Quiet software does not announce itself. It opens, it waits, it remembers. The best compliment it can receive is that nobody noticed it was there.

Every toolbar is a small argument about what matters. Most apps make too many arguments. A reading app should make one: the page matters.

> *NOTE: The fastest animation is the one you do not render.*

A window is a room. Corners, light, and proportion are not decoration; they are the physics of attention. A harsh edge makes a harsh thought.

Local First

Local-first is not a sync strategy. It is a promise that the thing you made will still be yours when the network is gone.

The database should fit in a pocket. The index should be a tool, not a service. The voice should be transcribed on the machine that heard it.

> *NOTE: A book should open in less time than it takes to doubt whether it will.*

Speed is a form of respect. When an app hesitates, it asks the reader to hold two thoughts at once: the thought they had, and the thought that the app might be about to work.

The Shape of a Day

Mornings are for reading; afternoons are for marking; evenings are for the map. This is not a productivity system. It is a rhythm that leaves room for surprise.

A good day ends with fewer open loops than it began with, but not zero. The remaining loops are the interesting ones.

NOTE: Keep the next page ready. That is most of the work.